

Polly Really Wants a Cracker--and She Might Know Your Name!

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You know parrots can talk, but did you know they might actually use names? A new study looked at **recordings** from more than 880 parrots living with people. The scientists, led by Lauryn Benedict from the University of Northern Colorado, found something amazing: many parrots use names as **labels** for specific people or animals, not just as random sounds.

Instead of traveling to jungles, the researchers used the ManyParrots project, which collects surveys and audio from parrot owners. They listened to 413 **recordings** where parrots said names. In 88 of those, the birds seemed to be using a name to point out a certain personlike calling "Mom" when they saw their owner, not just any human.

But parrots don't always use names the way we do. Some birds kept saying their own name to get attention, kind of like a kid yelling "Me! Me!" This shows they can **adapt** names for different social jobs. Christine Dahlin, another scientist on the team, said we can't be sure parrots think of names exactly like humans do, because we don't fully understand what's going on in their heads. Still, the findings suggest parrots have the **brainpower** and **voice skills** to use names in clever ways. They might even talk about someone who isn't in the room! There's still a lot to learn, but next time your parrot **squawks** "Buddy," maybe it really means you.

Word Treasure

recordings -- Saved sounds or voices, like when you record your pet making a noise so you can listen later.

labels -- Words or names we stick on things to tell them apart, similar to how a file folder has a name.

adapt -- To change the way you do something so it works better for a different situation.

brainpower -- The ability of a brain to think, solve problems, and learn new things.

voice skills -- The talent an animal has to make sounds that copy human speech or communicate in clever ways.

squawks -- The loud, sharp sounds that parrots and some other birds make.

Background you need

Lauryn Benedict is a scientist at the University of Northern Colorado who studies how animals communicate. She used the ManyParrots project, a big science project that collects surveys and recordings from pet parrot owners all over the world.

Parrots are famous for mimicking human speech, but scientists have long wondered if they understand any of it. This study suggests they might not just copy; they could be using names meaningfully, somewhat like how people use words to get another person's attention.

Even though we can't be sure what goes on in a parrot's mind, these findings show that birds have more brainpower and voice skills than many people expected.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists led by Lauryn Benedict and Christine Dahlin, using data from the ManyParrots project.

WHAT: They studied recordings of over 880 parrots and found evidence that parrots use names as labels for specific people, and sometimes use their own name to get attention.

WHERE: The study was done using online surveys and recordings from parrot owners around the world, without the researchers visiting jungles.

WHY: To understand if parrots use names with meaning and explore how clever their communication skills really are, instead of just mimicking sounds.

Why it matters

This discovery helps us see that animals might communicate in more thoughtful ways than we thought, and it reminds kids to pay close attention to their pets -- your parrot might actually be trying to talk to you, not just make noise.

Test what you remember

1. How many parrot recordings did the researchers listen to?
 - (A) 12
 - (B) 88
 - (C) 413
 - (D) 880
2. What was the amazing thing the scientists found in many recordings?
 - (A) Parrots could sing opera.
 - (B) Parrots used names as labels for specific people or animals.
 - (C) Parrots could count to ten.
 - (D) Parrots could read books.
3. Who led the study about parrots using names?
 - (A) Professor Yutaka Amao
 - (B) Sophia Zeng
 - (C) Lauryn Benedict
 - (D) Christine Dahlin
4. What is the ManyParrots project?
 - (A) A zoo that only keeps parrots.
 - (B) A project that collects surveys and sounds from parrot owners.
 - (C) A TV show about jungle birds.
 - (D) A school for teaching parrots to draw.
5. What did some parrots do with their own name?
 - (A) They kept repeating their own name to get attention.
 - (B) They whispered it when nobody was looking.
 - (C) They forgot it entirely.
 - (D) They wrote it in the sand.
6. What can scientists not be completely sure about yet?
 - (A) Whether parrots can fly.
 - (B) Whether parrots think of names exactly like humans do.
 - (C) Whether parrots have feathers.
 - (D) Whether parrots eat crackers.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: B

1. **Positive:** Animal lovers and pet owners find this exciting because it suggests parrots can build closer bonds with humans by using names meaningfully, which might mean we can teach them more words than we thought.
2. **Critical:** Some scientists argue that we can't be sure parrots understand names the same way people do; they might just be mimicking in clever patterns, and more controlled experiments are needed before we claim real name use.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):